

WHITE PAPER · TECHNICAL PAPER

Accounting Ontology: The Structural Layer Behind Reliable AI Assistance

How structured accounting concepts, relationships and definitions improve retrieval accuracy, consistency and reviewability.

● Product

● Accounting Firm

FORMAT

PDF · Free download

READING TIME

About 12 minutes

EDITION

Q4 2026

Educational research only. This paper does not constitute accounting, tax, legal, audit or compliance advice.

ABOUT THIS PAPER

Read this first.

This paper explains what an accounting ontology is, what it contains, and why it matters for AI assistance. It is written for product, technical and knowledge leaders who must judge whether a vendor’s “structured knowledge” is real. It is vendor-neutral by design, so you can use it to evaluate any approach, including ours.

WHO IT IS FOR	Product and technical leaders, accounting firm leaders and knowledge professionals who need AI assistance to work on meaning rather than on matching words.
THE QUESTION	Why does structure matter for AI that works with accounting knowledge?
THE THESIS	An accounting ontology gives AI a shared structure of concepts, relationships and definitions, so that retrieval, answers and review operate on meaning instead of on string matches.
THE EVIDENCE GATE	Can the system show which concepts and relationships shaped an answer, and can those be reviewed, versioned and corrected?
THE NEXT STEP	Test structure-aware retrieval on your own terminology, or request an enterprise briefing.
EDITION	Q4 2026. About 12 minutes to read. Free download.

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SUMMARY

Executive summary

Accounting vocabulary is full of words that change meaning with framework, jurisdiction and context. An AI that matches words will sometimes match the wrong meaning. An ontology is the structure that lets it match meaning instead.

An ontology is a formal description of the concepts in a domain and how they relate to one another: what kinds of thing exist, which are parts of which, which rules apply to which, and what each term means and where that meaning comes from. In accounting, that includes things like entities, periods, transactions, requirements and the jurisdictions and dates that govern them.

This paper argues that such structure is the layer that makes AI assistance more accurate to retrieve, more consistent to use and easier to review. It also argues that structure is only as valuable as its governance: an ontology that is unowned, unversioned or unreviewed becomes one more source of confident error.

Five questions that test whether structure is real

#	TEST	THE QUESTION TO PUT TO ANY VENDOR
1	Concepts	Which accounting concepts are modelled explicitly, and who defines them?
2	Relationships	Are relationships such as “applies in”, “is an exception to” and “supersedes” represented, or only similarity?
3	Sources and versions	Does each definition point to a source and carry a version and effective date?
4	Visibility	Can a reviewer see which concepts and relationships shaped an answer?
5	Governance	How are changes proposed, reviewed, tested and retired?

THE SHORT VERSION

Structure is not decoration. It is what lets a system know that two different words mean the same thing, and that one word means two different things.

What to do with this paper. Use Section 4 to understand how structure changes retrieval, Section 6 to understand what governing it takes, and Section 7 as a question list for your evaluation. If you want to test these ideas against ZoikoLogia™ with Kriton™ specifically, the last section explains how.

SECTION 1

The problem: one word, many meanings

Accounting language looks precise and is often not.

Terms that appear straightforward behave differently depending on context. "Revenue" and "turnover" can name overlapping ideas under different frameworks. "Period" can mean a reporting period, a billing period or a service period. "Entity" can be a legal entity, a reporting entity or a business unit. The same word can carry different obligations in different jurisdictions.

Plain-text retrieval treats these as strings. It finds passages that contain the words, which is useful but not the same as finding passages that mean what the user meant. Two failure patterns follow.

- **Homonyms.** The same word used for different concepts, so the system retrieves a passage about the wrong one.
- **Synonyms.** Different words for the same concept, so the system misses the passage that would have answered the question.

WHY THIS IS AN AI PROBLEM

A person reading "period" takes the meaning from context without noticing. A retrieval system does not, unless something tells it what the contexts are and how the concepts connect.

SECTION 2

What an accounting ontology is

A more structured kind of knowledge than a glossary, and a more explicit one than a search index.

These terms are often used loosely. The distinctions matter when you evaluate a vendor's claim to have "structured knowledge".

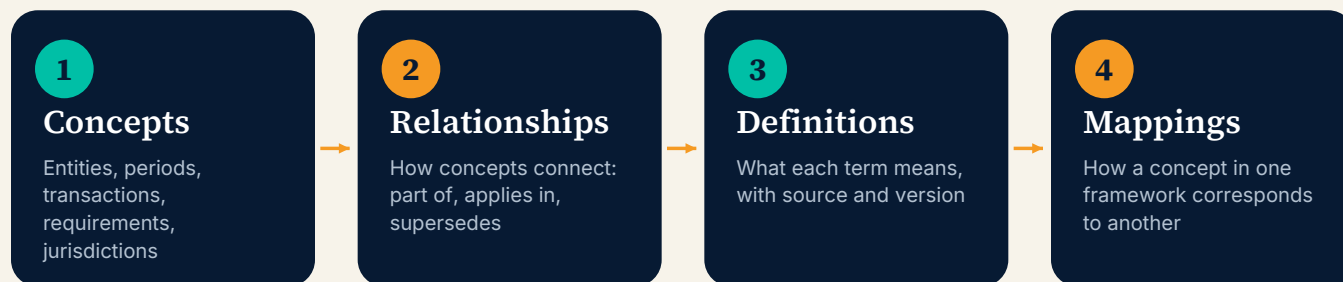
FORM	WHAT IT HOLDS	WHAT IT CANNOT DO
Glossary	Terms and definitions	Show how terms relate, or when a definition applies
Taxonomy	Terms in a hierarchy (is a kind of)	Express other relationships, such as exceptions or applicability
Ontology	Concepts, many kinds of relationship, definitions, and constraints on how they combine	Maintain itself. It needs ownership and change control
Knowledge graph	Specific facts and entities connected using an ontology's structure	Replace the ontology. It depends on one

An ontology describes the kinds of thing and how they relate. A knowledge graph populates that structure with particular facts. In practice, products mix them, so ask which of these a claim is actually describing.

SECTION 3

What an accounting ontology contains

Five kinds of content, each of which can be inspected.



A fifth element, **constraints**, rules out combinations that make no sense. A requirement that applies only to certain entities or periods, for instance, should not be retrieved for others.

RELATIONSHIP TYPE	WHAT IT EXPRESSES	WHY RETRIEVAL BENEFITS
Is a kind of	A concept belongs to a broader class	A question about the class can find passages about its members
Is part of	A concept is a component of another	Finds the whole when the question names the part
Applies in	A requirement applies to a jurisdiction, entity type or period	Filters out text that does not apply
Is an exception to	A provision modifies another	Brings the exception back with the rule
Supersedes	A newer provision replaces an older one	Prevents answering from the superseded version
Is defined by	A term depends on a definition	Keeps the definition with the term

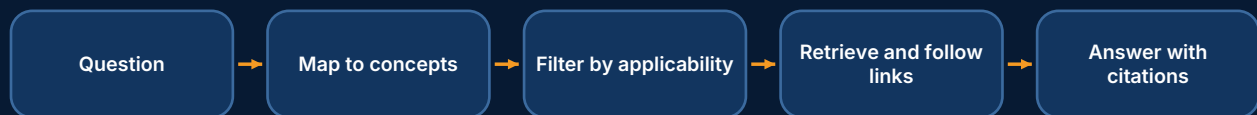
SECTION 4

How structure improves retrieval

Structure is designed to improve retrieval accuracy by helping the system understand what the question is about and what applies.

A structure-aware retrieval step does several things that plain text matching cannot.

- **Disambiguation.** Maps the words in a question to the intended concept, using context such as the workflow, entity type or period.
- **Expansion.** Recognizes that different terms name the same concept and retrieves for all of them.
- **Filtering.** Uses “applies in” and effective-date relationships to exclude material that does not govern the situation.
- **Traversal.** Follows relationships to bring in the exception, the definition or the superseding provision that goes with a rule.



Structure acts before and during retrieval. The mapping and filtering steps are where plain text matching has no equivalent.

These are design intentions, not guarantees. How much structure improves results depends on how complete and correct it is, and on whether the system actually uses it. Measure the effect on your own questions, as Section 7 describes.

SECTION 5

How structure improves consistency and reviewability

Two further benefits matter to professional firms as much as accuracy.

Consistency

When equivalent questions are phrased differently, a system working on words may answer them differently. A system working on concepts has a better chance of treating them alike. Shared terminology also makes outputs consistent across people and teams, which matters when several people contribute to one deliverable.

Reviewability

A reviewer checking an answer asks: which concept did the system think this was, and which source governed it? When the system's reasoning passes through named concepts and relationships, those can be shown. The review changes from "does this sound right?" to "was this the right concept, and the right source for it?".

Change impact

Structure also helps when something changes. If a definition or requirement is updated, relationships show which concepts, mappings and workflows touch it, so the impact can be assessed instead of discovered by accident.

A REVIEWER'S QUESTION

For any answer, ask the system to show which concept it mapped the question to and which relationship brought in the source. If it cannot, the structure is not doing the work claimed for it.

SECTION 6

Building and governing an ontology

An ontology is a living asset. Left unowned, it ages into a source of confident error.

Building one is a collaboration between accounting subject-matter experts, who know what is true, and knowledge engineers, who know how to represent it. Governing it is a continuing responsibility.

- **Scope deliberately.** Start from the workflows and questions that matter, not from an attempt to model all of accounting.
- **Assign ownership.** Every concept and definition has an accountable owner.
- **Tie definitions to sources.** A definition without a source cannot be verified or kept current.
- **Version and review changes.** Treat changes like changes to policy: proposed, reviewed, tested and recorded.
- **Test with real questions.** Competency questions confirm the structure can actually answer what it was built for.

COMMON PITFALL	WHY IT HURTS	MITIGATION
Too broad	Effort spread thin, quality uneven	Scope to priority workflows and expand deliberately
Unowned	Nobody keeps it current or accountable	Named owners and a change process
Unsourced definitions	Cannot be verified or updated	Link every definition to a source and version
Machine-generated, unreviewed links	Plausible relationships that are wrong	Expert review before relationships go live
Built once, never retired	Obsolete concepts linger	Review cycles and retirement rules

SECTION 7

Evaluating ontology-backed AI

A vendor's claim of structure should be tested on your own terminology and questions.

Do not evaluate structure by looking at a diagram. Evaluate it by watching behavior on questions that depend on it.

- Pick terms that are ambiguous in your work, and see whether the system resolves them correctly given context.
- Ask the same question in two different wordings, and check the answers align.
- Ask a question whose answer depends on jurisdiction or period, and see whether applicability is respected.
- Compare against plain retrieval on the same questions, and judge the difference on your own criteria.

QUESTION FOR THE VENDOR	WHY IT MATTERS
Which concepts are modelled, and who owns them?	Coverage and accountability
Is each definition linked to a source, version and effective date?	Verifiability and currency
How are jurisdiction and applicability represented?	Prevents correct text in the wrong place
Can we see which concepts shaped an answer?	Reviewability
How are changes proposed, reviewed and tested?	Governance
Can we extend it with our own policies and terminology?	Fit to your organization
What can we export if we leave?	Portability and exit

SECTION 8

Where ZoikoLogia™ fits

We built ZoikoLogia™ with Kriton™ around these ideas. You should hold us to the same checks as everyone else.

ZoikoLogia™ with Kriton™ is a governed AI accounting intelligence platform. Its design intent includes structured accounting knowledge, meaning concepts, relationships and definitions tied to approved sources, so that retrieval and review work on meaning and so that an answer can be traced through the concepts and sources behind it.

How much structure is in place for your workflows, and how it behaves on your terminology, is something to verify on your own questions, not to assume from a description. The checks in Section 7 apply to us as they do to anyone.

We would rather you verify than trust. Evidence stays with the pages that own it, and each page states what is currently published and what is not:

IF YOU WANT TO CHECK	WHERE TO LOOK
How the organization is governed	Governance
Compliance information and its status	Compliance
How data is protected	Privacy & Security
Provider evaluation and questionnaires	Provider Due Diligence
Accessibility	Accessibility
Documented technical interfaces	API Reference
Recent product changes	Release Notes
Where to start	Trust

WHAT THIS PAPER DOES NOT CLAIM

It does not claim any certification, attestation or compliance status. It makes no statement about pricing, availability or outcomes for your organization, and it provides no accounting, tax, legal, audit or compliance advice. Current evidence and its status are on the Trust pages.

SECTION 9

Next step: test structure on your own terminology

The most informative evidence is how a system handles the words that are ambiguous in your work.

Bring a short list of terms that cause confusion in your firm or finance team, and a few questions that depend on jurisdiction or period. Watching how the system resolves them is more informative than any description of its structure.

Request Enterprise Briefing

The recommended next step. Decision context for product, technical, finance and governance stakeholders.

Book a Demo

A guided walkthrough of the product.

Request Pilot

A controlled evaluation of one defined workflow.

API Reference

Documented technical interfaces, where published.

Find each on the ZoikoLogia™ website. A submission through any of them does not confirm pricing, availability, response timing or commercial terms.

What to bring to the conversation

BRING	WHY IT HELPS
Ten ambiguous terms from your work	The best test of whether structure is real
Pairs of questions that mean the same thing	To check consistency
Questions that depend on jurisdiction or period	To test applicability
Your own policies and terminology	To see how extension would work
The subject-matter experts who would own concepts	Ownership decides whether structure stays accurate

APPENDIX A

Glossary

TERM	MEANING IN THIS PAPER
Ontology	A formal description of the concepts in a domain, how they relate, how they are defined and what constraints apply.
Taxonomy	A hierarchy of terms based on “is a kind of” relationships.
Knowledge graph	Particular facts and entities connected using an ontology’s structure.
Concept	A defined idea in the domain, such as an entity, period or requirement.
Relationship	A named connection between concepts, such as “applies in” or “supersedes”.
Mapping	A correspondence between a concept in one framework and a concept in another.
Disambiguation	Resolving which meaning of a term is intended, using context.
Competency question	A question the structure is built to answer, used to test it.
Effective date	The date from which a definition or requirement applies.

APPENDIX B

Important information

This paper is educational research. It does not constitute accounting, tax, legal, audit or compliance advice, and professional decisions must remain subject to qualified human review and applicable rules. The tiers, tables, checklists and scorecards are illustrative frameworks to support your own evaluation, not statements about the performance of any product. Statements about ZoikoLogia™ describe its design intent and are not guarantees of outcomes. Verify current status on the relevant pages of the ZoikoLogia™ website.

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